

FAREWELL NOTE
Chouhan in Delhi for a BJP central committee meeting, Sept. 13

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023

MADHYA PRADESH

ON A SHAKY WICKET

SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN'S BATTLE LIES BOTH WITHIN AND OUTSIDE HIS PARTY AS HE STRIVES TO OVERCOME THE ANTI-INCUMBENCY OF 16 YEARS

By **RAHUL NORONHA**

"*Aisa bhaiyya nahin milega. Jab main chala jaunga, to bahut yaad aaunga* (You won't find a brother like me. You will miss me a lot when I am gone)," Madhya Pradesh chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan told a group of women beneficiaries in Ladkui village in Budhni constituency, a seat he represents, on October 1. Two days later, at an outreach programme in Sehore, Chouhan asked the assembled gathering: "Should we fight the election or not?"

For someone who has held the reins of his state for over 16 years, Chouhan's successive statements betrayed the insecurity of a man fighting for political survival, within and outside his party. Chouhan is no stranger to the heat and dust of an election; he thrives on such occasions, in fact. He led the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to victory in 2008 and 2013 with comfortable margins, and the